

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Twenty20



THE INDIAN TEAM CELEBRATES THEIR WORLD T-20 VICTORY IN 2007 WHILE THE RAJASTHAN ROYALS BEAM WITH JOY AS THEY LIFT THE IPL TROPHY IN 2008

GAME Changer

Twenty20 cricket has moved the epicentre of cricket to India, raising not only players' salaries and scores but also injuries

By Nasser Hussain |

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- Some may say this is cricket's guide to er... dummies, but no. T20 is cricket's shorter, sharper and much richer version
- It's where the audience spends no time waiting for the next batsman to walk in because if that doesn't happen in 90 seconds he is timed out. Dressing rooms are just kit-bag areas; baseball-style dugouts have become the vogue.

Perhaps my England coach Duncan Fletcher saw it all coming. When I retired in 2004, he congratulated me on getting a job with Sky TV, and offered me some advice, "Remember Nass, keep your finger on the pulse, because in five years the game will change completely." The game has certainly changed in this decade and Twenty20 (T20) has been its great innovation, the big development for cricket in this time.

In 2003, my county Essex gave me a T20 kit which is still in its wrapping at home. I never got to open it as I was playing for England and did not want to play T20 cricket. Given the way I was blocking in the Tests, maybe Essex did not even want to pick me for T20. It's a young man's game, I was at the end of my tether and was not bothered about it. But today I am a massive fan of T20 and have enjoyed working on it.

I love both domestic and international

T20; I take my children along for games. It is the only cricket they watch. They find Tests and even fifty-over cricket a bit slow.

When T20 first started in England in 2003, cricketers thought it was a bit of fun. They did not see it as serious cricket, did not do a lot of practice for it, would just turn up and think of it as a break from their normal day job. As the crowds built up, it took county players by surprise. Fridays at, say Essex's ground at Chelmsford, used to be one man and a dog going through a gate. Suddenly, thanks to T20, the businessmen who worked in London began to come off their trains on Friday nights and go straight for the T20 evening game. There would be sellout crowds and people would be queuing around the block.

It was a bit of a shock for players really. They even began to get a bit nervous about it. County pros weren't used to playing in front of full crowds. For young players, however, that was a big step they had to get used to. T20 made a massive change in English county cricket.